

On the night of October 18, as Sheridan arrived back in Winchester, Early's men were hugging a precipitous mountain trail as they rounded the lightly picketed Union left flank. Dawn on the 19th opened with a Rebel yell and a thunder of guns. The Union soldiers were caught literally in their beds. Thousands fled to the rear in panic. Wagons, supplies, some 24 cannons, and 20 battle flags fell to Early's men; but barefoot, famished, and in rags, most of them turned aside to plunder, and Early called off the pursuit. "This is glory enough for one day!" he exulted.

Increasingly alarmed, Sheridan arrived at the scene to see the shambles of his army pouring rearward. Ordering up fresh troops from Winchester, Sheridan rode along the wagon-thronged Valley Pike, cursing, cajoling, coaxing, and cheering; waving his hat forward. "Come on back, boys! Give 'em hell, God damn 'em! We'll make coffee out of Cedar Creek tonight!" Increasing his pace almost to a gallop, he kept it up for nearly 12 miles (19km), roaring encouragements and waving his hat, until by some miracle of inspiration the army began to steady, then to reform its lines. By 4:30 p.m., the tide was turning. An overwhelming wave of bluecoats then rolled back into its former camps. In the chaos, the Confederates turned in flight. As Union cavalry slashed at their flanks, fleeing soldiers clogged the Valley Pike so thickly that at one place a small bridge collapsed. Everything the Confederates had captured, and more, they now lost, to the point where Early's army nearly ceased to exist. "When we left the field that evening," General John B. Gordon acknowledged, "the Confederacy had retired from the Shenandoah."

435,802 The number of bushels of wheat that were destroyed or seized by Sheridan's troops in the valley, along with 77,176 bushels of corn, and 874 barrels of flour.